INTRODUCTORY SOMMELIER COURSE AND EXAM

AND

CERTIFIED SOMMELIER THEORY EXAM

CURRICULUM GUIDE

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SOUTH AMERICA - CHILE

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will learn where Chilean wine regions are located, understand the unique climate, and recognize the primary grape varieties planted.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will learn the major geographical influences that affect vine growing, how the major grape varieties grown in Chile arrived in the country, have a familiarity with the Denominación de Origen (DO) system, and recognize major growing areas and major subregions. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to recommend and sell food pairings with wines from Chile to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	**Located on the west coast of South America in the Southern Hemisphere.** 2,670 miles or 4300 km north to south. 217 miles or 350 km wide. Spans 17-53°S latitude.	
Geography: Climate Categories	Hot desert to cool to cold from north to south.	
Geography: Physical Features and Moderators	**Desert:** Atacama Desert **Ocean:** Pacific Ocean, provides cool breezes and fog. **Mountains:** **Andes Mountains:** Elevation and diurnal shifts. **Coastal Range**: Creates rain shadow from cold Pacific.	
Soil: Type and/or Name	Sand	
Grape Growing	No presence of phylloxera (because of sandy soil). Irrigation is essential from the Andes. Mostly ungrafted vines.	
Winemaking		
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Sauvignon Blanc, Chardonnay	
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot, Carménère	Syrah, País
Wine Law	**Denominación de Origen (DO) System:** Refers to a geographic place of origin only, no other additional laws. Region, Subregion, Zone, Area.	Minimum Percentages: Variety/Vintage/Origin Labeling is 75%. In practice, EU requires 85% in all three categories.

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Subject Name: SOUTH AMERICA - CHILE

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Wine Law / Appellations	**Aconcagua DO** **Subregion: Casablanca DO** Cool, maritime climate west of the Coastal Range. Chardonnay, Sauvignon Blanc, Pinot Noir **Valle Central DO** Warm to hot climate. Located between the Coastal Range and Andes. 80% of Chilean production. Cabernet Sauvignon, Carménère, Merlot **Subregion: Valle de Maipo DO** Surrounds Santiago in the Maipo River Valley. Most of the major historical wineries are located here. Cabernet Sauvignon	**All Regions** **Aconcagua DO** Casablanca DO **Valle Central DO** Rapel DO Colchagua DO Cachapoal DO Curicó Valley DO Maule DO Valle de Maipo DO
Label Terms		
General Terms	**Humboldt Current:** Cold current coming from Antarctica running along the west coast of South America.	
Style	Often big, intense, fruit driven, high-alcohol wines.	
Classification		
Producer/Proprietary Brand		Concha y Toro, Santa Rita, Errázuriz, Casa Lapostolle, Carmen
Vintage		
History & Lore	**1500s:** Grapes being grown in the South American Spanish colonies. **1600s:** Prohibitive laws from the Spanish restricting wine production. **1800s**: Political independence and influx of European immigrants led to an expansion of viticulture. **1970s-80s:** Influx of foreign investment.	
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		
Business of the Sommelier		

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SOUTH AMERICA - ARGENTINA

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will learn the history, general climate, major wine regions, and grape varieties of Argentina.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will have a deeper knowledge of the winemaking regions of Argentina and factors of its unique terroirs. A Certified Sommelier will be able to recognize iconic producers and be able to recommend and sell food pairings with wines from Argentina to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	Located in South America, east of the Andes Mountain Range and west of the Atlantic Ocean.	
Geography: Climate Categories	Continental to arid desert	
Geography: Physical Feature	Andes Mountains are an average of 900 meters / 3,000 feet above sea level and create a rain shadow.	Salta is 1500-2000 meters / 5,000-6,000 feet in elevation, the highest in Argentina. Mendoza is 600-1200 meters / 2,000-4,000 feet in elevation.
Soil: Type and/or Name		
Grape Growing	Irrigation is essential and flood irrigation or modern drip irrigation is used. Melted snow from the Andes provides a water source. Major diurnal shifts.	Malbec can have an electric purple color due to increased sun exposure at higher elevations causing intense pigmentation.
Winemaking	Torrontés commonly has no oak influence. New or used, French or American oak are all common for Malbec and Cabernet Sauvignon.	
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	**Torrontés** Chardonnay	
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	**Malbec** Cabernet Sauvignon	Bonarda, Tempranillo, Syrah
Wine Law	85% min to list the grape variety on a label.	
Wine Law / Appellations	**Salta**: **Subregion:** Cafayate known for Torrontés. **Mendoza:** **Subregions:** Luján de Cuyo and Uco Valley known for Malbec. **Patagonia:** Cool due to southern latitude. Malbec, Cabernet Sauvignon, Pinot Noir	
Label Terms		
General Terms		

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Subject Name: SOUTH AMERICA - ARGENTINA

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Style	Torrontés is a highly aromatic grape with soapy, floral, and fruity flavors. It has medium-plus to high acidity making it unique amongst other varieties.	
Classification		**IG:** Indicación Geográficas, GIs in English **DOC:** Denominación de Origen Controlada system
Producer/Proprietary Brand	Catena	Know a couple of producers for service exam recommendations.
Vintage		
History & Lore	Vineyards were revitalized by Italian and Spanish immigrants.	
Service of Beverage		Some high-end Malbec and Cabernet Sauvignon can benefit from decanting.
Food and Beverage Pairing		Malbec and Cabernet Sauvignon pair well with steak and chimichurri.
Business of the Sommelier		

INTRODUCTORY & CERTIFIED THEORY CURRICULUM

Subject Name: SOUTH AFRICA

Learning Outcome Introductory Sommelier Course: After studying this section, a student will be able to locate the general area where South African wines are made, recognize important grape varieties and important wine regions.

Learning Outcome Certified Sommelier Exam: After studying this section, a candidate will be able to locate the general area where South African wines are made, understand the climate of South African wine regions, recognize important grape varieties, recall the basics of the Wine of Origin (WO) System, identify primary growing areas, and understand how important historical and political events have shaped the industry as we know it today. Certified Sommeliers will recognize iconic producers and be able to recommend and sell food pairings with wines from South Africa to a guest.

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Geography: Location	Western Cape is the heart of South African viticulture.	
Geography: Climate Categories	Maritime climate on the coast. Mediterranean to hot moving inland. Cooling effect of Atlantic and Indian Oceans.	
Geography: Physical Feature	Indian Ocean Atlantic Ocean Table Mountain	
Soil: Type and/or Name		
Grape Growing:	Strong winds that blow onto shore to the vineyards help mitigate pest issues. Cold Atlantic currents from Antarctica cool parts of the coast line.	**Cape Doctor Wind:** Strong, dry, south-easterly wind that blows onto shore and the vineyards from spring to summer. Helps mitigate pest issues. **Benguela Current:** A frigid current in the Atlantic Ocean from Antarctica that cools portions of the South African coast. **Old Vines Project:** Objective is to preserve old vines and promote sustainable viticultural practices to create more old vines.
Winemaking:	History of distillation and brandy production, plus sweet, oxidative, fortified wines.	**Cap Classique:** a traditional method sparkling wine from South Africa.
Wine: White Grape Variety Names	Chenin Blanc, Chardonnay, Sauvignon Blanc	
Wine: Red Grape Variety Names	Syrah/Shiraz, Pinot Noir, and Pinotage	Pinotage is a crossing of Cinsault x Pinot Noir
Wine Law	**Wine of Origin System:** If from a single appellation, must be 100% from the appellation. Rigorous process for certification. **From Largest Area to Smallest:** Geographical Unit Region District Ward	

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Subject Name: SOUTH AFRICA

	Introductory Level	Certified Sommelier Exam
Wine Law / Appellation	**Western Cape** **Coastal Region:** Swartland, Cape Town, Stellenbosch, Paarl, Constantia **Cape South Coast Region**: Elgin, Walker Bay	**Western Cape** **Klein Karoo Region:** Sweet fortified wines and brandy) **Coastal Region:** Franschhoek Valley **Cape South Region:** Cape Agulhas, Overberg
Label Terms		
General Terms	**KWV:** Koöperatieve Wijnbouwers Vereniging van Suid-Afrika. The Co-operative Winemakers Union of South Africa is important for creating laws and regulation.	
Style		
Classification		
Producer/Proprietary Brand		Graham Beck, Mulderbosch, Hamilton Russell, Klein Constantia, A. A. Badenhorst, Eben Sadie
Vintage		
History & Lore	1600s Dutch settlement, Simon van der Stel Phylloxera & Anglo-Boer War KWV (mentioned above) Apartheid and its effect on the export market. Move from oxidative and fortified wine production to world class wines.	
Service of Beverage		
Food and Beverage Pairing		Wines range from sparkling to light and crisp to rich and intense. These are great recommendations for those looking for a world class wine from an undervalued area.
Business of the Sommelier		